

Mollusks

With more than 90,000 species, few invertebrate groups are more varied than mollusks. Their most noticeable feature is often their shell. Not all mollusks have one, but for most, it provides protection from attack. Mollusks typically move by creeping, but this group also includes fast swimmers, such as octopuses and squid.

Chitons

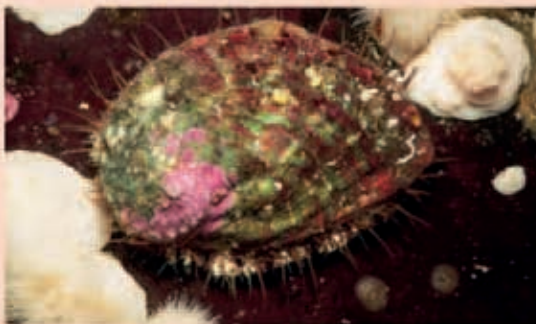
A chiton's shell is made of eight hinged plates surrounded by a muscular girdle. Underneath is a suckerlike foot, which chitons use to clamp themselves to rocks. Chitons live in the sea and feed mainly on algae. Like snails, they scrape up their food with a ribbonlike tongue, or radula, armed with hundreds of microscopic, toothlike denticles.



This chiton is attached to a rock in a tidal pool. Its head is pointing to the left.

Gastropods

Snails and their relatives make up a group called the gastropods. Most have a coiled shell, produced by a body layer called the mantle, and a suckerlike foot. Gastropods are very common in the sea, but many species live on land.



Abalones graze algae on rocky shores. Their shells are iridescent on the inside, and people make jewelry from them.



Land snails' eyes are on a long pair of retractable tentacles. They breath air through a space in their mantle that acts like a lung.



Land slugs look like land snails without a shell, but some have a tiny internal shell called a shell plate.



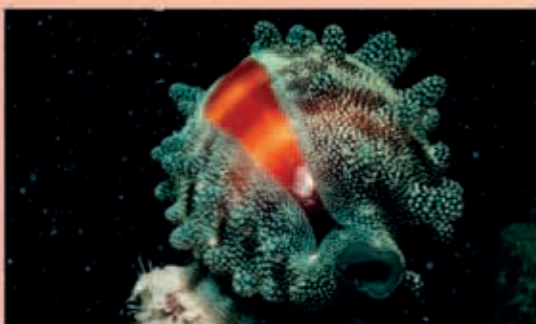
To drift across oceans, bubble raft snails use a raft made from bubbles of mucus. Their shells are wafer-thin.



Conches are large tropical sea snails with thick, heavy shells. They move by flicking a hard-edged foot.



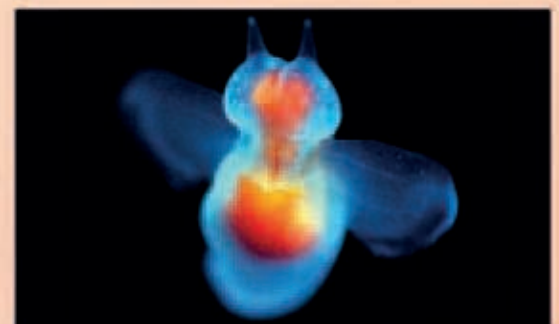
Limpets graze on algae and live on rocks exposed to waves. They have strong suckers and simple conical shells.



Cowries can extend their mantle up and over their egg-shaped, glossy shell. Both shell and mantle may be brightly patterned.



Sea slugs don't have shells. These creeping marine gastropods are often vividly colored, with external gills and horns.



Sea butterflies are sea snails that live in open water. Their foot extends sideways and beats like a pair of wings.